

Rating Area 6: Central PA / Lehigh Valley

Hub: State College / Allentown-Bethlehem | Counties: Centre, Columbia, Lehigh, Mifflin, Montour, Northampton, Northumberland, Schuylkill, Snyder, Union

21.5%	102%	443,024	160,000+
PID-approved avg. individual rate hike	avg. net premium increase, 2026	PA enrollees as of June 1, 2026	cumulative PA terminations

THE STATEWIDE PICTURE

The federal enhanced premium tax credits expired December 31, 2025, and Congress has not restored them; combined with the Pennsylvania Insurance Department's (PID) approved 21.5% average individual-market rate increase, Pennie reports the average net premium for the affected population rose 102% for 2026 (Pennsylvania Insurance Department, 2025; Pennie, 2026a). Statewide, 85,000 people dropped Pennie coverage during Open Enrollment; as of June 1, 2026, cumulative cancellations exceed 160,000 and total enrollment stands at 443,024 (Pennie, 2026a, 2026b). Pennsylvania's own relief program, the Act 54 state subsidy, remains unfunded as the state budget missed its June 30, 2026 deadline for the fifth year running (Spotlight PA, 2026).

CARRIERS & RATES IN THIS AREA

This wide, non-contiguous rating area spans both the Centre County / State College market, served heavily by Geisinger and Keystone Health Plan Central, and the Lehigh Valley, where Highmark markets its narrow "my Direct Blue Lehigh Valley EPO" (Pennsylvania Insurance Department, 2025b).

ACTIVE NETWORK DISRUPTION: UNITEDHEALTHCARE & LVHN

A separate, ongoing contract dispute is displacing Lehigh Valley patients on two different timelines: Medicare Advantage members lost in-network LVHN access January 26, 2026 (special enrollment period ran through April 30); commercial/employer-plan members, roughly 50,000 people — including VA Community Care Network enrollees, who are **not** exempt — face the same change April 26, 2026 (Pennsylvania Department of Aging, 2026; WFMZ, 2026). If you have a UHC plan and see LVHN providers, confirm your specific plan type directly; don't assume you're unaffected.

YOUR CONSUMER PROTECTIONS

If a directory error sends you out-of-network: 28 Pa. Code § 9.725 caps your liability at in-network cost-sharing, and Act 252 of 2023 presumes an undisclosed out-of-network balance bill illegal. The federal IDR process (45 C.F.R. § 149.510) is a *provider-vs-plan* tool only — you cannot file one yourself; use the protections above instead.

Enroll / compare plans: pennie.com or 1-844-844-8040	File a complaint: pa.gov/consumer or 1-866-722-6675
Free legal help: php.org or 1-800-274-3258	Medicare counseling: PA MEDI 1-800-783-7067

SOURCES (APA)

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